

THE EMBER GUARD – ASPIRANTS

THE WORLD

Long ago, a war to banish the demons was won, but even in victory the world was poisoned. In the final clash, the lowlands were smothered in a lethal, shifting miasma known as the Roiling Fog.

Those who survived fled to the mountains, carving new lives from the high peaks. Now, only the tallest summits rise above the tide. Settlements cling to ridgelines, connected by cableways, gliders, and perilous bridges. Between them lies only wind, stone, and the gray sea below.

The Empress Laseen, once the God Emperor's right hand, turned on him when his zeal became tyranny. She now rules from Emberglass Peak, commanding the Ember Guard — a small, elite order of heroes who travel the Peaks to defend the people of the empire, and preserve the fragile unity of the highlands.

THE EMBER GUARD

Every few years, the Empress calls for new blood. Each settlement sends its Aspirants — those deemed strong, wise, or steadfast enough to undertake the Pilgrimage of Ember. The road to Emberglass Peak is long and perilous. Some never arrive.

It's said that the Empress herself watches the Aspirants' journey through divination, weighing every choice and consequence. Few know exactly what she seeks, only that some reach Emberhold and are permitted entry, while others are turned away.

Those who enter Emberhold are given emblems of that order, becoming full members of the Ember Guard — the empire's wandering heroes, and its last defense against the Fog and what stirs within it.

YOUR ROLE

You are one of the chosen of the city of Stonehollow. You have been named Aspirant to the Ember Guard. Tomorrow, you depart the safety of your home to begin the pilgrimage across the Peaks — a journey that will test not only your skill and strength, but your heart.

Your story begins with that first step — the climb through storm and cold, proving that courage and hope can still find a foothold in the mountains.

STONEHOLLOW

A midsized settlement, somewhat smaller than most cities, but too large to be a town, Stonehollow was built inside a massive cavern mouth that opens onto a sheltered ridge. Houses and farms are all inward-facing, protected from storms and Fog. The cavern's natural acoustics make it a place of song, ritual, and echoing public assemblies.

TONE AND THEMES

The setting for this campaign is somewhat dark, but not hopeless. The light is fragile sometimes, but it's real, and the characters will have the power to make it stronger.

You'll face moral choices, desperate odds, and the weight of legacy; but also fellowship, and the stubborn spark of humanity that refuses to be smothered.

Be bold, take risks, lift each other up. That's how heroes are forged in the Peaks.

CHARACTER CREATION GUIDELINES

The campaign will use the Draw Steel system. All options from the core book are open to you, except the Devil and Time Raider ancestries.

If you have a strong concept for one of these that could fit the setting, talk to me — we might find a way — but they don't immediately fit very well into the setting.

CHARACTER EXPECTATIONS

This is a story about people who choose to stand against the dark, not because they're fearless, but because someone has to. Your character can be reluctant, burdened, or imperfect, but they should strive to do what's right in the end, even when it costs them. The pilgrimage will test that resolve. Who you become along the way is as important as if/when you reach the end.

PROMPTS

The Ember Guard draws Aspirants from all walks of life. You might be:

- A miner or craftsman of Stonehollow seeking to honor your kin's legacy.
- A scholar, priest, or mage hoping to study the truth behind the Fog.
- A hunter or guide who knows the mountain's moods better than most.
- A soldier, mercenary, or guard who longs to serve something greater.
- A wanderer, outlaw, or exile searching for redemption.

Whatever your origin, ask yourself: What did Stonehollow see in you? Who and/or what are you leaving behind? How do you feel about being called?

The Pilgrimage of Ember is a test of both mind and body. It will take you through high passes, ruined keeps, and Fog-scoured valleys — places where courage and judgment matter as much as steel.